

sineadmurrayirelandedit

Travel Radio Australia and we're continuing our series on Ireland and we have Sinead Murray, the Trade and Industry Partnerships Manager for Tourism Ireland with us on the program. Sinead, welcome to the program. Thanks very much, nice to be here Geoffrey, thank you for having me.

Tourism Ireland, you cover the whole of Ireland from your offices in both North and South Ireland, tell us a bit about Tourism Ireland and what you do. Yes of course, Tourism Ireland is the international marketing body, as you said, for the island of Ireland. We were born out of the Good Friday Agreement and we work incredibly closely with our sister agencies on the island of Ireland, Folch Ireland, who promote the Republic of Ireland and are responsible for product development and experience development there, and our agency Tourism Northern Ireland in Northern Ireland.

So we work very closely with them, we ensure that Ireland is out there and that it's top of mind for visitors when they're making their holiday decisions. My role is to encourage Irish industry to come out to markets because nobody can sell like the Irish themselves and talk about the wonderful experiences and holiday options that are available on the island of Ireland, and again working closely with Folch and Tourism and I to ensure that we have the right people in the right place in the right markets. And Ireland is such a tremendous destination, having grown up there myself in Dublin as a child, and I mean places like County Wexford and County Kerry and all those wonderful places.

Tell us a couple of your favourites because you know Ireland pretty much inside out now. I do now, that's like asking who your favourite child is, that's not a fair question Jess. I mean every corner of Ireland is beautiful, I mean it all has its own unique charms, whether it's from the coastal sceneries you talked about, down in Kerry, right up to the north coast where the Open was held in Royal Portrush this year, and I'm sure the golf is brilliant, but the scenery and the hospitality is just as good.

If I was to say I'm from a small place called Monaghan myself, which is in the area of Ireland's ancient east, it's on the border with Northern Ireland, but I think no matter where you go in Ireland, it's the people who make it, because we talk about it a lot, the warm hospitality, and we're not nosy, we're curious, we want to know where you're from, we want to ensure you have a good time, and no matter who you meet, they'll always have a story for you, or a welcome for you, nothing's of any trouble, I've heard of people arriving and landing in airports, missing a taxi and getting lifts home with other people, and it's just part of our nature, it's who we are, we like to welcome visitors, we love to share our culture, our heritage, our history, our music, and of course our drink, as you can see, Michael Distiller is with us today from the lovely part of the world, in Salt Hill, in County Galway, over in the west of Ireland. The west, again, is very beautiful, because you can find a lot of areas where we still speak Irish to this day, so our very own language, so it's a very different place, people think they know Ireland, but they don't, even I'm

discovering hidden gems as I go along, so it's a wonderful place where you receive a really warm welcome no matter where you go, and our range of accommodation options are, with everything from five-star hotels, right down to great three, four-star hotels, and the B&B sector, where again, you get to meet your hosts and the wonderful food that they produce, it's all locally produced, everybody talks about our natural dairy, milk and butter, and there's nothing like brown soda bread for your breakfast in the morning in Ireland, so we've a great range of options, lots of things to see and do, and again, the golf is second to none, I mean, we have well over 400 golf courses on the island, for such a small island, it is great, and we've a third of the world's links courses, so we know our golf, and we're very welcoming to visitors, and anyone who comes has a great time, and always say they want to come back, so that's a really good sign too. Big thing these days is people grabbing a camper van and just touring around, being free to, and that must be a big thing in Ireland now, and the fact that you can get around Ireland very easily is fantastic for that.

Oh absolutely, and we have, I'm sure visitors have heard about the Wild Atlantic Way, which is the longest touring route, it stretches right down to Kinsale and County Cork, right up to Donegal in the north, and you can get lost on roads in Ireland, but that's part of the fun, that's part of the adventure, and that's where you get meeting people who will give you directions, but it gives you that freedom to go and discover where you want to go, we have great facilities for camper vans, people have done, taken a week, 10 days to go around the island, and they've really, really enjoyed it, because it's an opportunity to get out into the countryside, discover those lesser hidden gems, and as I say, to get meeting the people and experience the culture there, and little restaurants that they may not have come across, had they been staying in bigger cities, or go with the flow, you don't need a plan in Ireland. You know Ireland very, very well Sinead, we're talking with Sinead Murray, the Trade and Industry Partnerships Manager with Tourism Ireland. Sinead, I always ask this, a couple of your hidden gems, which are not so well known, but are absolutely fantastic.

Ah, that's a really good question, we have a few, there are, are you talking golf courses, or just in general, maybe your favourite golf courses, and a couple of really fantastic out of the way places. Yes, well in terms of golf courses, you're spoilt for choice as I say, we are spoilt for links courses, but we've wonderful parkland courses too, there's a lovely little village, Glasson, which has a great parkland course, also some fantastic restaurants there, I mean the food is second to none, and very often people may miss it because it's not on the Wild Atlantic Way, but it is in the Hidden Heartlands, lovely part of the world, that's why we call, it's the Hidden Heartlands, and that's an area to discover, with the wonderful peat bogs there, which have preserved lots of artefacts for generations, and we're still discovering wonderful things from Bronze, Stone Age, right, right back, there's nothing like doing a bit of turtle cutting, if anybody comes to Ireland, it's not, it's not something that you'll always do, but it's great, just an experience for people to have as well, you can go to little distilleries, brew your own gin, take it home with you, check it out, there's perfumeries along the West Coast, where again, you get to pick the botanicals, the lovely flowers that are there, make your own scent, you can get to make your own chocolates, again using

those natural Irish ingredients and products, we even have facilities where you can stay in a farmhouse, and you can cook, or you go for a kayak at midnight, and come back and be served with the most gorgeous food, that's made with seaweed, that's been caught on the shores, and you can forage for seaweed yourself, make lovely things out of it, or cook with it, so it's all about being at one with nature, being at one with the land, and not disturbing that, we are really big into our sustainability, we're well known for our green fields in Ireland, and that's not, that's not by accident, you know, we are very conscious of the environment, we want visitors to have a really good time, but also know that they're giving back to the community, because like everywhere else, a lot of places are struggling, tourism is a wonderful way to get visitors out into the community, to get meeting people, and to see that benefit in the local communities, whether that's restaurants, or little bars, or small B&Bs, or sectors that may struggle otherwise, if you didn't have visitors, so we're very, very welcoming of visitors, there are so many hidden gems, Geoff, I don't even know how to do them, so that's the fun of it, go out and explore, and find those hidden gems that mean much to you, you know, so, and everybody likes something different, but whatever, whatever your interests, you'll find something in Ireland. And we can't mention Ireland without mentioning Irish whisky, right next door to us here, we have an Irish whisky tasting from a distillery, tell us about those people.

Yes, they're a little company called Mickle Distillery, and they're over in the west of Ireland, in a lovely area called Salt Hill, and it's a lovely story, it started off by the grandfather, and he kept the whisky distillery going, and his grandson now runs the distillery, they're actually the first licensed distillers of Putschine, which was an old drink in Ireland, long before whisky, to us, whisky in Irish is Ischgo Beatha, or the water of life, and yeah, we do, we do invite, because it's great stuff, you can see from our stand here that people are really enjoying it, enjoying the experience, and again, we've different flavours of whisky throughout, this is quite a peaty one, really, really nice, but incredibly smooth, I think a lot of people here have said, what a wonderful whisky, and they're really interested in having it, so yeah, I know it's a lovely, and it's a beautiful, beautiful part of the world, we even had Eugene Levy, I always get that surname wrong, sorry, the actor who was over on us, and he, he fell in love with the place as well, and yeah, got behind the scenes of the whisky distillery, and it's a great spot to go again, to do some whisky tasting rather, and you're there with the people who actually produce the product, and know what they're talking about in the history, it's again, it's a generation, it's a lovely family story, and it's a lovely business, and it's great to be able to support it. And a couple of other places I'd like to mention you, must-sees really, in the south of the country, if you are going to Dublin, you have to pop in and see the Guinness Brewery, and I went there when I was 10, and they gave us a little, little taste, and I think I've, it's been a favourite of mine, you know, all through my life, and that's a fabulous thing, and in the north, where you're from, we have the Titanic Museum in Belfast. Yes, the Titanic, everybody knows the story about Titanic, but no visit to Belfast is complete without a visit to the Titanic Centre, it's not just about the ship, it's about the human stories, so when you go through it, you know, you're seeing all the names of people who, those who survived, those who didn't, there's artefacts from the ship itself, we even have the violin that was played when, unfortunately,

the Titanic went down, and it's a very, very emotive experience, photographs of people with their children, and you can, you can just imagine the horror that they must have gone through, but again, from that, it also talks extremely well about Belfast's rich shipbuilding heritage, and how that changed, and indeed, how important the industry was, but it's also a testament to how far we have come, and how peace on the island has been so fantastic for the country, and it's, it's just a wonderful place to visit, telling the story of Belfast and its people, and how the resilience, and the humour that still exists there, and again, wonderful restaurants, pubs, all within good, short walking distance of each other, and a great range of accommodation, and then it's not too far either from the Causeway coastal route, where we have the very famous Giant's Causeway, that was.

That's where, actually, Harland Wharf in Belfast is where the Titanic was born, and was built, and just to stand there, in the Causeway, you know, where, where it was actually created, must be a tremendous feeling. Yes, it is, because you, you can feel nearly the hairs in the back of your neck, and the energy from that, and the vibe that must have been there at the time, but there isn't even an area where you can listen to the recordings of what it must have been like to work in the shipyards, and the constant banging and that, and I mean, every, young children, right up to grown men, and it was very much part of the Belfast life, so, back then, so yeah. Well, thank you so much for being with us, Sinead.

It's Sinead Murray, the Trade and Industry Partnerships Manager with Tourism Ireland, and how can people find out more online about your organisation? Recommend our website, ireland.com, which will give a great range of options for your holiday, if you're, you're looking for it, and we really look forward to welcoming you to Ireland, and, as I say, you'll be, you'll be guaranteed a very warm welcome, and you'll want, you'll go back wanting more. And I can say in Gaelic, Sláinte, and I can say Diaos Mérida as well, which is God bless you. Go raibh maith agat sef, agus have a great show, and slán go fóill.